Today, when an architect seeks to emulate an "Indian" style, especially one associated with royal grandeur or Oriental luxury, the tendency is to draw upon the Mughal style and, especially, the Taj Mahal. Indian luxury hotels , especially those seeking an international clientele, often include chhatris, onion domes, crenelated walls and elaborate tiles and mosaics. Even the tackier side of Orientalism, such as the "Corn Palace" of Mitchell, South Dakota, possesses onion domes, chhatri-esque minarets and fierce devotion to perfect symmetry[23].

Building the Taj

Once Shah Jahan had the project in mind, he gave a large palace to a man named Maharajah Jai Singh as a trade for the land on which the Taj Mahal would sit. The project, which required an estimated 20,000 workers, first went about excavating land to deal with its proximity to the Yamuna River, which included steps like filling the foundations with dirt above the banks of the river. At the same time, the project required different kinds of materials, some of which came from India but much of which was only located in other spots across the continent. For example, the white marble came from places like Makrana, while turquoise came from Tibet and crystal came from China, so workers were dispatched with hundreds of elephants to find the necessary materials and carry them back.

For the mausoleum itself, the laborers made a scaffold so extensive that the designers were afraid it would take years to safely remove, so the emperor allegedly let the people know they could take bricks from the scaffolding, thereby speeding up the process. After that, an earthen ramp was constructed on which the building’s materials could be moved to the site, and these materials were so heavy that some of it required having 30 oxen to move them. Once the materials had arrived, the laborers used pulleys to raise the marble into place. That entire process took about 12 years to complete, and that didn’t include construction of the other parts of the Taj Mahal, including its soaring minarets, the great gate, and the mosque on the site. It would take another decade for the rest to be completed.

Of course, in addition to building the actual Taj Mahal, it had to be decorated, and artisans were brought from across the continent to work on it. For example, calligraphy was done by men hailing from Syria and Persia, while marble sculptors and stonecutters came from other parts of India.